SUBMISSION to the Federal Election 2025

1

assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;

2

potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;

Three news reports from major news sites I have found since this inquiry opened have come from The Sydney Morning Herald, The Financial Review and The Western Weekender. They came up immediately in my search engine but I have no way of knowing if they are typical.

In an article in The Sydney Morning Herald dated 01/05/2025, 'Threats, 'skulduggery' and neo-Nazis prompt AEC warning about voting booths', the authors have listed 17 aggressive incidents.

In an article in The Financial Review dated 01/05/2025, 'Candidates reminded of need for 'lawful, respectful campaigning'', the authors have listed some of the same and three additional aggressive incidents.

In an article in The Western Weekender dated 01/05/2025, 'AEC urges respectful behaviour at voting centres', the authors have listed no additional aggressive incidents.

AEC Commissioner Jeff Pope said most pre-poll interactions had been cordial. "While there is a lot of media coverage of incidents occurring, reports of unsavoury behaviour are relatively limited," he said.

Using the word 'purported' in the first matter of this inquiry demonstrates there is no hard data to examine before determining whether any action should be taken.

Recommendations

1. The AEC has a Disinformation Register which successfully reports incidents found or brought to their attention, and how the incident was investigated and the result.
   The AEC could report data pertaining to aggression at the polling booths across Australia, based on police reports. This would provide verifiable data after the next election.
2. The AEC Commissioner request drop-ins by local police at polling booths if requested by the Presiding Officer.
3. Limit the number of candidate representatives and signs allowed to be within a distance of the polling booth. This should be based on the number of entry pathways to the booth.
4. Exclude third party players from the candidate representatives' area.

7

the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

1. **The potential for fixed terms and the length of the parliamentary term**

Increasing the length of the Parliamentary term will reduce our democratic rights. A good government has nothing to fear and a bad government will be there longer than it should be.

Section 7 of the constitution states, "The senators shall be chosen for a term of six years, and the names of the senators chosen for each State shall be certified by the Governor to the Governor-General."

Section 28 of the constitution states, "Every House of Representatives shall continue for three years from the first meeting of the House, and no longer, but may be sooner dissolved by the Governor-General."

These changes would require a referendum.

I would not want to go to another referendum without a constitutional convention to assist the public to understand the consequences of the change.

2. **The number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate**

The proportional representation of the states and territories in the Parliament does not need to be changed.

The Senate was designed to have an equal number of senators from each state for the express purpose of giving each state, no matter the size, equal representation in the federal parliament. The Northern Territory and the Australian Capital Territory are not states, but in 1974 were given two senators to provide representation in the upper house.

The principle of 'one vote, one value' does not apply here. The number of enrolled voters in each state is irrelevant. The AEC enrolment rate for the election of 2025, for NSW was 5,694,989. Enrolment in the ACT was 322,356. If we were to use the 'one vote, one value' principle for the Senate based on these numbers, there would be one senator for each 161,178 votes in the ACT. That would give NSW 35 senators (5,694,989 / 161,178). The Northern Territory has less than half the number of enrolled voters in the ACT.

The principle of 'one vote, one value' applies in the House of Representatives. It provides proportional representation of voters, no matter in which state or territory they live, or whether they live in a high or low populated area.

The AEC enrolment rate for the election of 2025, for all Australia was 18,098,797. Divide that by the number of Members gives 119 859 voters per Member as an average. In NSW the lowest number of voters in an electorate is Robertson 114,983. The highest is Hunter 132,272.

Compare that to the U.S.A. where each House of Representatives district has an average of 300,000 voters.

Why the US House of Representatives has 435 seats – and how that could change

Apportionment and Redistricting Process for the U.S. House of Representatives | Congress.gov | Library of Congress

Why do we need more Members of the House? The Members will continue to debate the same number of bills.

The Members will continue to attend Parliament near the same number of weeks.

With the Prime Minister away from Australia so often at multi-national meetings, Parliament will not sit more often.

PM Anthony Albanese has reduced the staff of the opposition (Coalition), the Greens, other smaller parties and independents making their job far more difficult to assist and represent the people of their electorate.

Parliamentarians' personal staff – Parliament of Australia

In 2022 the Prime Minister reduced the crossbench adviser allocation from four to one.

In 2025 the leaders of the Greens and Coalition received confirmation from the Prime Minister that nearly 20 shadow ministerial positions would be cut from the Coalition and a "small" cut would be made to the Greens' staffing. The government with 94 seats said it will reduce its own staffing by between 10 and 15 positions. One Nation has been allocated a pool of four staffers despite gaining two extra senators. Last term Senators Pauline Hanson and Malcolm Roberts each received two staff.

This bucks the overall trend of an increase in personal staff in the last decade.

Government needs a strong opposition to hold it to account while at the same time representing and assisting their constituencies. That is our system of government, our democracy. That is what has made it work in the best interests of the people.

If the people are not being represented well, the government should restore its opponents and crossbench staff numbers before going down this costly path.

Recommendations

1. Do not change the proportional representation of the states and territories in the Parliament.
2. Restore opposition and crossbench staff numbers before going down the path of increasing the number of parliamentarians.